State of New Jersey Technology Circular

System Architecture Review (SAR) Procedure 16-05-P1-NJOIT

Approved By: Kevin Dehmer, Chief Technology Officer

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1. OBJECTIVE

The New Jersey Office of Information Technology (NJOIT), under the direction of the Chief Technology Officer (CTO), perform a System Architecture Review (SAR) to ensure that technology solutions for the Executive Branch of State are designed, developed, and deployed to maximize benefits and functionality while minimizing costs and risks. The SAR process also ensures compliance with cybersecurity and architecture standards and best practices. It provides for the controlled introduction of new technologies and the appropriate reuse of existing technology to increase returns on investment.

The SAR process informs agency representatives regarding:

- Cybersecurity and privacy requirements;
- Cross-Agency interoperability of systems;
- Data sharing and reuse;
- Opportunities to leverage economies of scale and/or existing solutions;
- Impact on existing technology infrastructure and operations;
- Prioritization of resources, including staff levels; and
- Disaster recovery & business continuity requirements.

2. PARTY PARTICIPATION

All relevant stakeholders from NJOIT, New Jersey Office of Homeland Security and Preparedness (NJOHSP), the Division of Purchase and Property (DPP), and the reviewee-Agency will participate in SAR reviews. Participation will be done either through meetings or electronic review, depending on the nature of the checkpoint.

Participation will be determined based on the expertise required for the specific project. The Agency's Business Owner/Project Sponsor or their designee must attend scheduled SAR review meetings.

3. CRITERIA

A SAR is required when a new solution/component/module is being developed or acquired, including but not limited to:

- Procurement of a Commercial-off-the-Shelf (COTS) package;
- Utilizing an "X as a Service" solution, including, but not limited to Software (SaaS), Platform (PaaS), or Infrastructure (IaaS);
- Custom development software applications;
- Integrating new hardware within the Garden State Network;
- Installing new hardware at any of the State Enterprise Data Centers.
- When a significant enhancement or modification is being made to an existing solution. Significant enhancements/modification examples include, but are not limited to:
    - Addition, modification or removal of enterprise solutions or functionality such as e-mail, e-payment, myNJ (SSO), or reporting functionality;
    - Addition, modification or removal of application specific functionality such as adding/removing a server call, adding/removing a web service call;
    - Changes to an extranet or firewall;
    - Changes to any information system platform (e.g. database, web server, application server, etc.);
    - An information or data system with application design changes since the last SAR;
    - A vendor solicitation with an information technology requirement. e.g., Request for Proposal (RFP); Request for Quotation (RFQ); Request for Information (RFI).

4. PROCEDURE

The SAR process should begin as early as possible in the project lifecycle, ideally before any procurement or development activities begin. There are four stages to the SAR process.

Step 1: Technology Initiation Proposal (TIP)

Submission of a Technology Initiation Proposal (TIP) by the Agency is the required first step.

- A TIP Request, with complete supporting documentation, must be submitted to SAR. SAR related forms for submission can be found at https://nj.gov/it/whatwedo/sar/. Any questions regarding completion of the documentation may be sent to SAR@tech.nj.gov.
- Only one phase of SAR should be requested at a time (Technology Initiation Proposal, Logical, Validated Design, or Implementation).
- Electronic reviews (eReviews) are held as warranted.
- SAR documents older than one year must be updated with current information before submitting.
- If providing an update, resubmissions must identify the reason(s) for the change or modification.
- Scheduling is handled on a first submitted, first reviewed basis.
- TIP meetings are scheduled weekly on Monday afternoons.

A TIP review is performed before a final RFP/RFQ/RFI is generated and after the Agency obtains internal approval of the business case. During the TIP review, NJOIT shall facilitate discussion and:

- Evaluate the documentation provided. Documents should be reviewed section by section during the meeting, any changes or questions must be noted;
- Confirm the project aligns with the State's enterprise architecture strategy, standards, and processes;
- Confirm the project aligns with the State's data and information management strategy, standards, and processes;
- Evaluate the request's impact on existing infrastructure or IT capacity;

- As appropriate, recommend leveraging existing State assets and consider how the proposed solution might be used by others;
- Confirm the plan complies with State and/or federal cybersecurity requirements;
- Review and validate data classification for the proposed solution; and
- Identify the costs and risks of certain decisions.

Upon completion of the TIP review, a marked up TIP document is distributed along with a meeting RECAP (excel spreadsheet) via e-mail to all participants. The TIP document and RECAP include discussion points from the meeting and any Action Items that must be resolved before the Logical SAR.

Step 2: Logical SAR (LSAR)

For the next step, the Agency submits their completed LSAR (On Premises or Cloud) to request a review, along with their updated RECAP spreadsheet.

- An LSAR review is performed before any hardware or software is installed, before any coding has begun, and after an RFP or RFQ is awarded.
- Reviews may be conducted electronically (eReview) or via scheduled meetings, depending on the complexity of the project and the nature of the feedback required, at the discretion of the SAR internal review team.
- Meetings are scheduled on the second and fourth Thursdays of the month. Exceptions to this are the months of November and December where the reviews may be rescheduled to alternate Thursdays due to the holidays.

During the LSAR review, NJOIT shall facilitate discussion and:

- Evaluate the documentation provided. Documents are reviewed section by section during the meeting and any changes or questions are noted;
- Ensure that capacity, resources, hardware and software needs are identified;
- Ensure that the data requirements are defined;
- Ensure that infrastructure requirements are defined; and
- Reaffirm that cybersecurity requirements are defined.

Upon completion of the LSAR meeting (or eReview) a marked up LSAR document is distributed via e-mail along with a meeting RECAP (excel spreadsheet) to all participants,

which includes discussion points from the meeting and any Action Items that must be resolved before the final SAR, the Implementation review (IR).

Step 3: Validated Design

In this step, the Agency creates and submits their completed design document to the NJOIT Solutions Architecture (SA) Team.

- The SA Team provides guidance in the creation of the design document when needed and then presents them to NJOIT's Information Security Unit (ISU) and NJOHSP for approval.
- The Validated Design checkpoint is the point in a project's lifecycle that marks the end of the design phase. This means that the system components, data and control flows, and interfaces have been finalized and documented in diagram form.
- The final design is also used as the reference point for any operational work that needs to be done, (e.g., firewall rule requests, server build work, etc.). Completion of Validated Design is a prerequisite for the IR stage.

During the Validated Design, NJOIT shall facilitate discussion and:

- Update the logical design from the LSAR with system components, data and control flows, and all interfaces;
- Ensure that required resources and integrations are identified; and
- Ensure the design is vetted by security teams, to ensure compliance with appropriate governance.

Upon approval of the Validated Design, NJOIT will notify the Agency that the Validated Design is complete. The Agency then needs to submit work requests to trigger NJOIT business units' work related to the solution.

Step 4: Implementation Review (IR) SAR

In this final step, the Agency submits their completed IR form (On Premises or Cloud) to request a review, along with their updated RECAP spreadsheet.

- An IR SAR should be requested no less than two weeks before go-live of any phase.
- An IR is held electronically and there is a five-business day review cycle.

During the Implementation Review, NJOIT shall facilitate discussion and:

- Evaluate the documentation provided. Documents are reviewed section by section and any changes or questions are noted;
- Determine whether the project is ready for deployment – all outstanding action items are resolved and/or remediated;
- Ensure that all cybersecurity requirements are successfully tested; and
- Ensure that the date for deployment, impact on other systems and related deployment activities have been assigned, agreed upon, and communicated to stakeholders well in advance.

Upon completion of the review, a marked-up IR document is distributed via e-mail along with a RECAP (excel spreadsheet) to all participants, which includes discussion points from the review and any Action Items that must be resolved before project end.

During an e-Review:

- There is a five-business day review cycle.
- NJOIT distributes the SAR request and documents to all participants for their review and comment.
- The Agency is responsible for answering any questions/concerns raised during the eReview.
- NJOIT compiles questions and responses into notes, which are sent out at the end of the e-Review cycle, along with any notes on Action Items that have been raised. (Note: Please allow approximately five business days after the end of the stated review period for the closing notes to be distributed.)
- NJOIT will cancel the e-Review and schedule a formal meeting if the questions raised during the review cycle require more discussion than can be successfully concluded through e-mail.

NJOIT reserves the right to change or amend this Procedure at any time.

5. RELATED FORMS AND DOCUMENTS

Forms and templates required for the SAR process can be found on the NJOIT website: https://nj.gov/it/whatwedo/sar/. Ancillary SAR documents may also be found at this location.

6. ADMINISTRATION

This Policy is administered and monitored by the CTO at 300 Riverview Plaza, Trenton, NJ 08625. The Policy must be reviewed annually; however, the CTO reserves the right to change or amend the Policy at any time.

Signature on File — 7/14/2026

Kevin J. Dehmer, Chief Technology Officer — Date

Version	Published Date	CTO	Sections Modified	Description of Modifications
1.0	12-12-2016	Christopher J. Rein		Original Published Date
2.0	09-13-2024	Christopher J. Rein	1-5	
3.0	07/14/2026	Kevin J. Dehmer	1-4	Updated Format and Procedures. Updated CTO and Governor Name. Clarified descriptions; removed PSAR step